

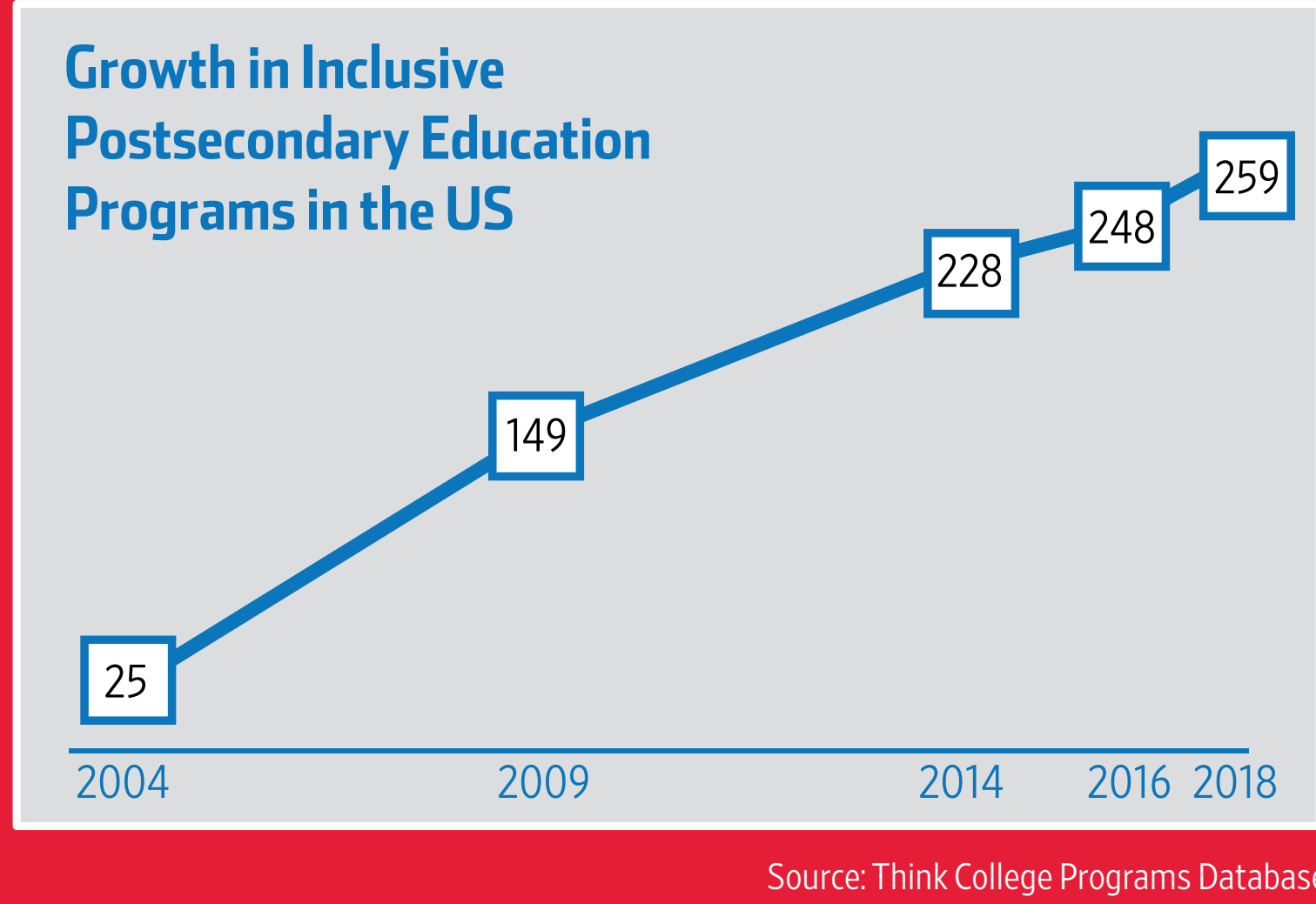
The Role and Impact of Vocational Rehabilitation in Inclusive Higher Education for Students with Intellectual Disability and Autism

A Study of the RRTC on Vocational Rehabilitation Practices and Youth



BACKGROUND

Over the past decade, the field of inclusive higher education has expanded considerably, offering a growing number of options for students with intellectual disability (ID) and /or autism to access higher education (Grigal & Smith, 2016; Grigal, Hart, Smith, Domin, Weir, & Sulewski, 2016). Simultaneously, the role of vocational rehabilitation (VR) agencies in supporting youths' transition to work has expanded under the Workforce Innovation and Opportunities Act (WIOA). Given this convergence of factors, there is a need for better understanding of how VR and institutions of higher education (IHEs) can coordinate efforts to support students with ID and autism to succeed in college and beyond.



STUDY 1: SECONDARY DATA ANALYSIS

Research Questions

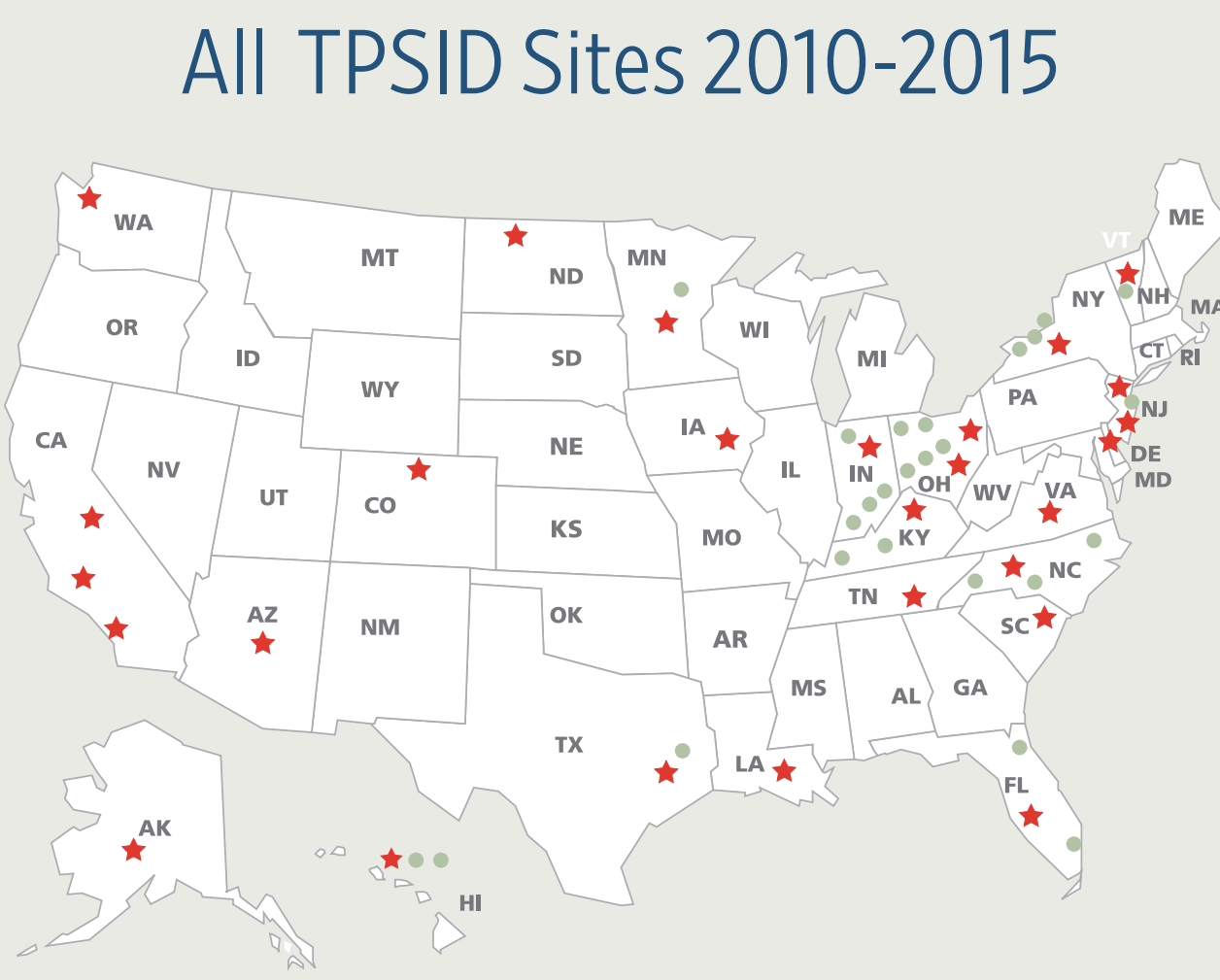
- RQ 1:** What is the frequency of interaction and role of VR agencies partnering with IHEs serving students with intellectual disability and /or autism?
- RQ 2:** What partnership attributes are related to positive outcomes for students?

Method

Secondary analysis of program and student data from Transition Postsecondary Programs for Students with Intellectual Disabilities, or TPSIDs, at 52 IHEs nationally.

WHAT'S A TPSID?

Transition and Postsecondary Programs for Students with Intellectual Disability, or TPSID, are model demonstration projects funded by the US Department of Education. Through a Request for Proposals (RFP) process, grants were awarded to institutions of higher education or consortia of institutions of higher education to enable them to create or expand high quality, inclusive model comprehensive transition and postsecondary programs for students with intellectual disabilities.



STUDY 2: CASE STUDIES

Research Questions

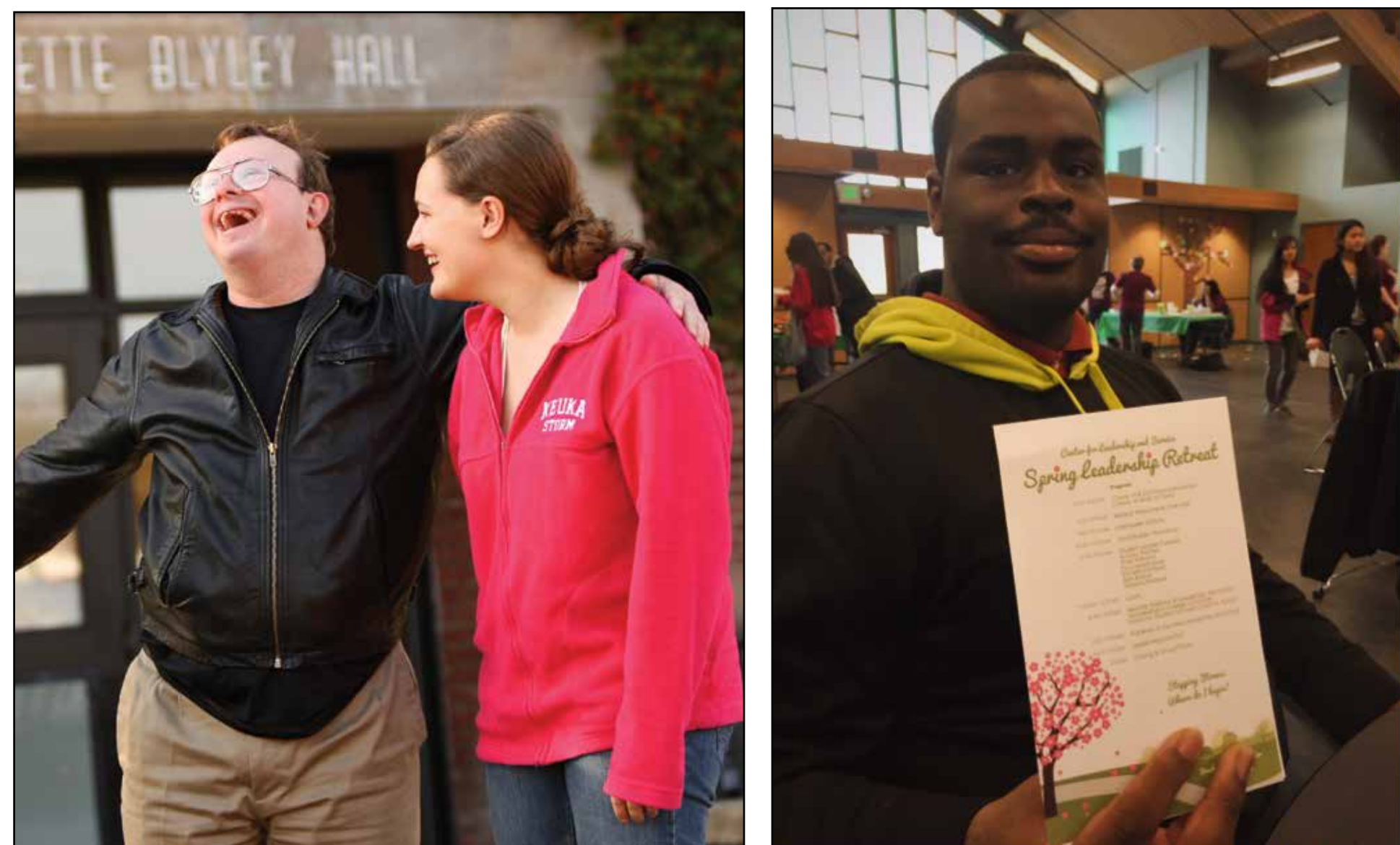
- RQ 3:** How are higher education programs partnering with VR to support individuals with ID and /or autism?
- RQ 4:** How is the higher education -VR relationship established and maintained?
- RQ 5:** What supports does VR provide to higher education programs and students?
- RQ6:** How do higher education / VR partnerships enhance supports and outcomes for individuals with ID and /or autism?

Method

Intensive case studies of institutions of higher education (IHEs) that have established effective partnerships with VR. Studied four exemplary partnerships across the country by interviewing IHE staff, VR staff, students, and parents at each site.

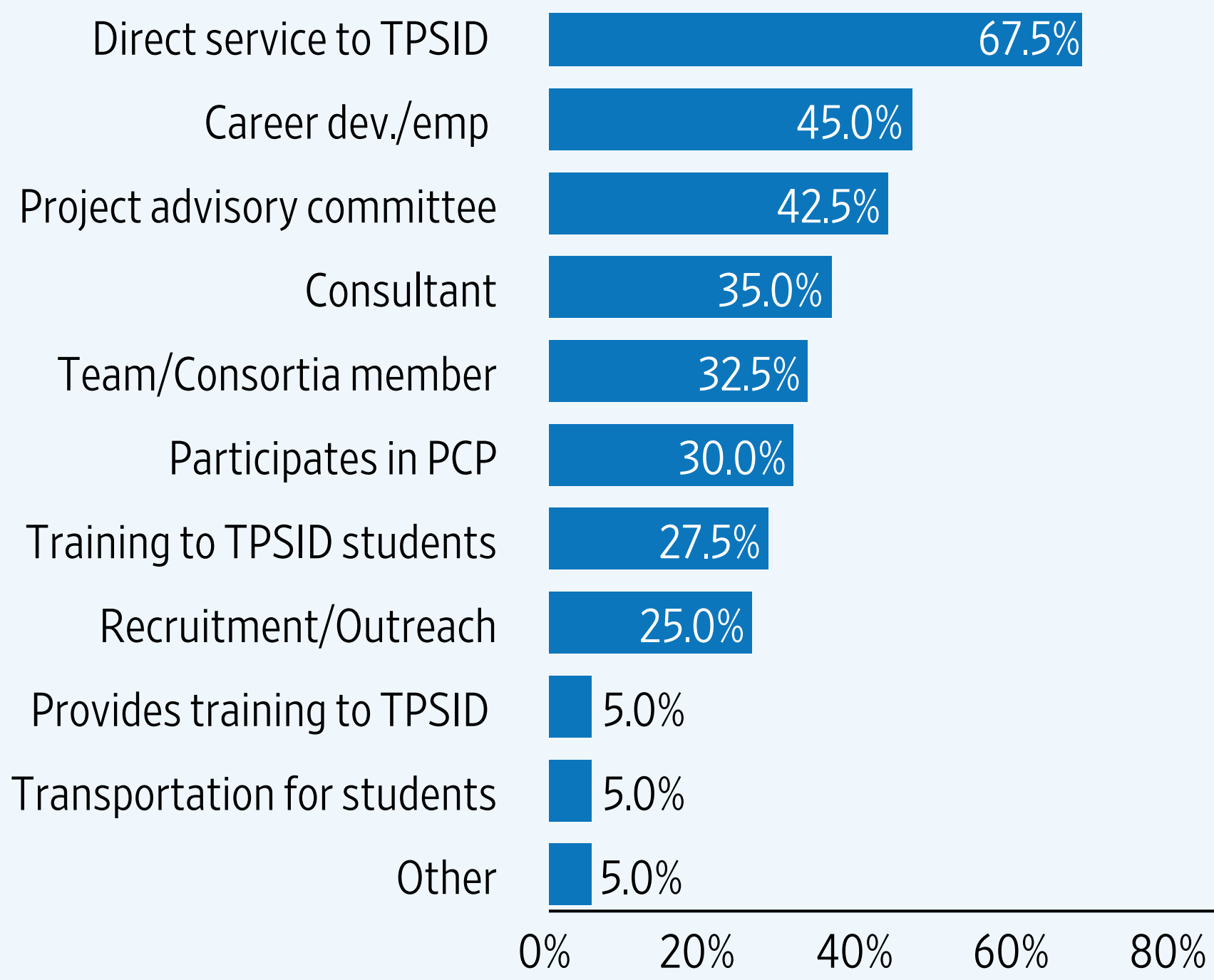
KEY ACRONYMS

VR: Vocational Rehabilitation
IHE: Institution of Higher Education
ID: Intellectual Disability

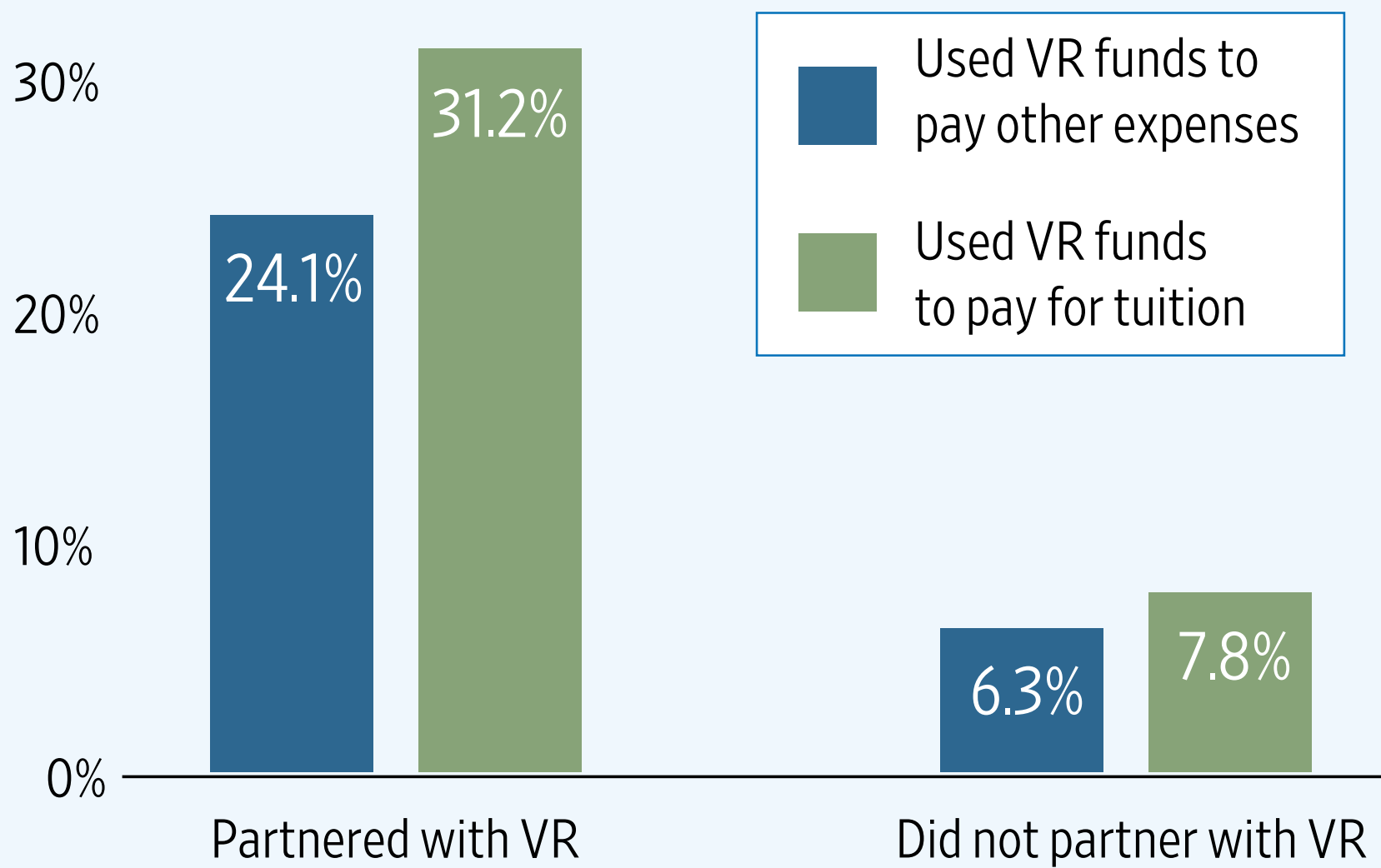


SECONDARY DATA ANALYSIS

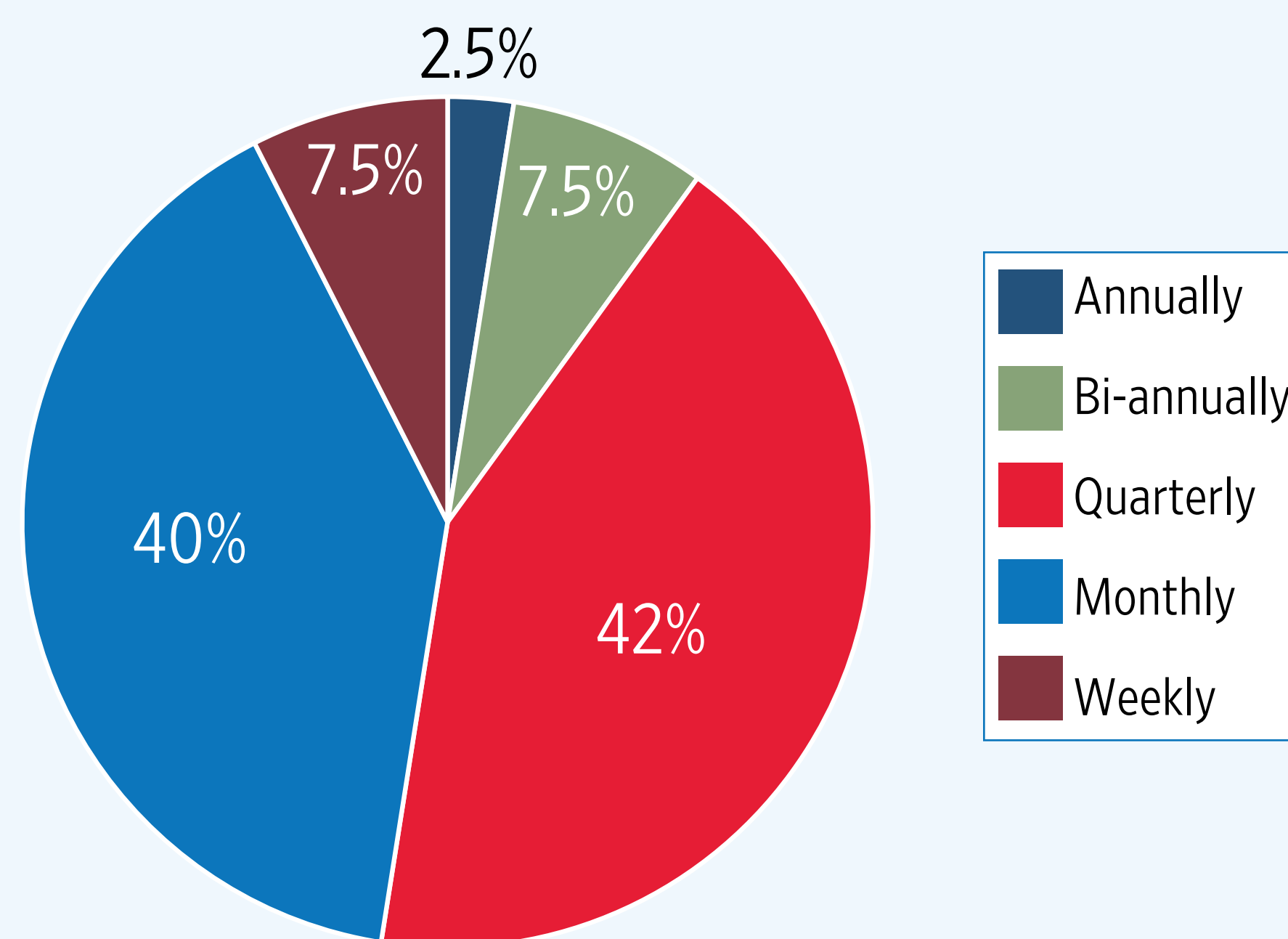
The most common roles for VR partners were providing direct services to students, providing funds for student tuition, and serving on advisory boards.



VR was more likely to pay student tuition in programs that have a partnership with VR.



Most TPSID programs interacted with their VR partners on a quarterly (42%) or monthly (40%) basis.



REFERENCES

- Grigal, M., & Smith, F. (2016) Vocational Rehabilitation Partnerships with Higher Education Programs Serving Students with Intellectual Disability. VR and Youth Rehabilitation Research and Training Center Fast Facts, Issue No. 01. Rockville, MD: TransCen, Inc.
- Grigal, M., Hart, D., Smith, F. A., Domin, D., Weir, C., & Sulewski, J. (2016). Think College National Coordinating Center: Annual report on the transition and postsecondary programs for students with intellectual disabilities (2014–2015). Boston, MA: University of Massachusetts Boston, Institute for Community Inclusion.

CASE STUDIES

Partners reported that VR supported postsecondary success in a number of ways:

- » Counseling high school students on college options
- » Providing financial assistance for tuition and other expenses
- » Providing supports such as VR counseling, assistive technology, benefits planning, and supplemental job coaching while in college
- » Supporting the transition from college to employment

"Tuition assistance [from VR] is just huge and has been an incredible game changer [because it] makes [inclusive higher education] no longer a rich kids club. This really opens the doors to a much more inclusive possibility."
—VR counselor

Communication was essential to success and included:

- » Formal communication structures such as quarterly or monthly meetings
- » Informal communication among ground level staff, which happens much more frequently
- » Cultivation of personal relationships leading to a sense of partnership in working to support students

"I'm communicating with the individual [VR] counselors probably several times a week... Mostly emails, but phone calls if things need to move faster."
—College employment support staff

ABOUT THINK COLLEGE

Think College is a national organization dedicated to developing, expanding, and improving research and practice in inclusive higher education for students with intellectual disability. Think College is based at the Institute for Community Inclusion at the University of Massachusetts Boston.

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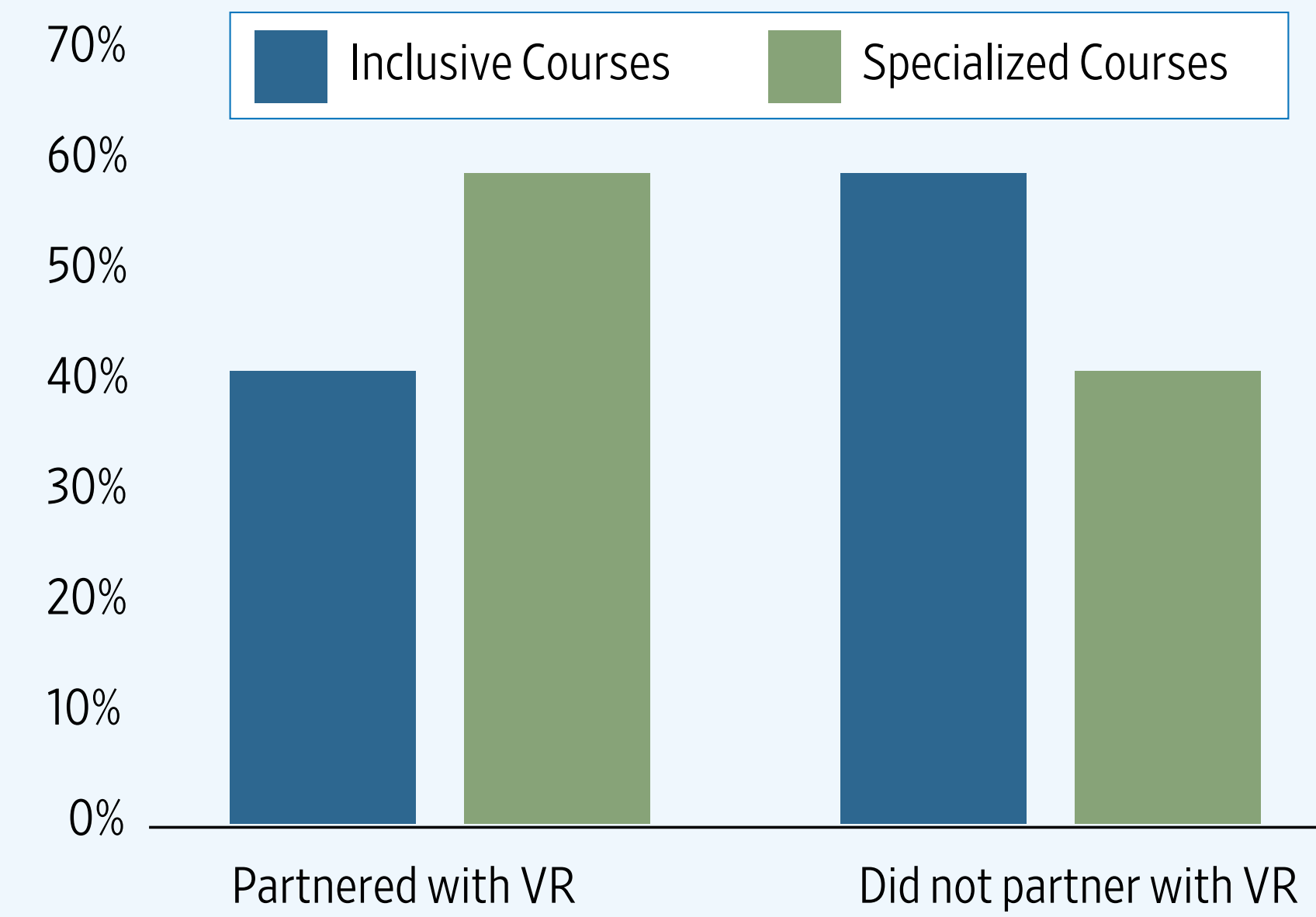
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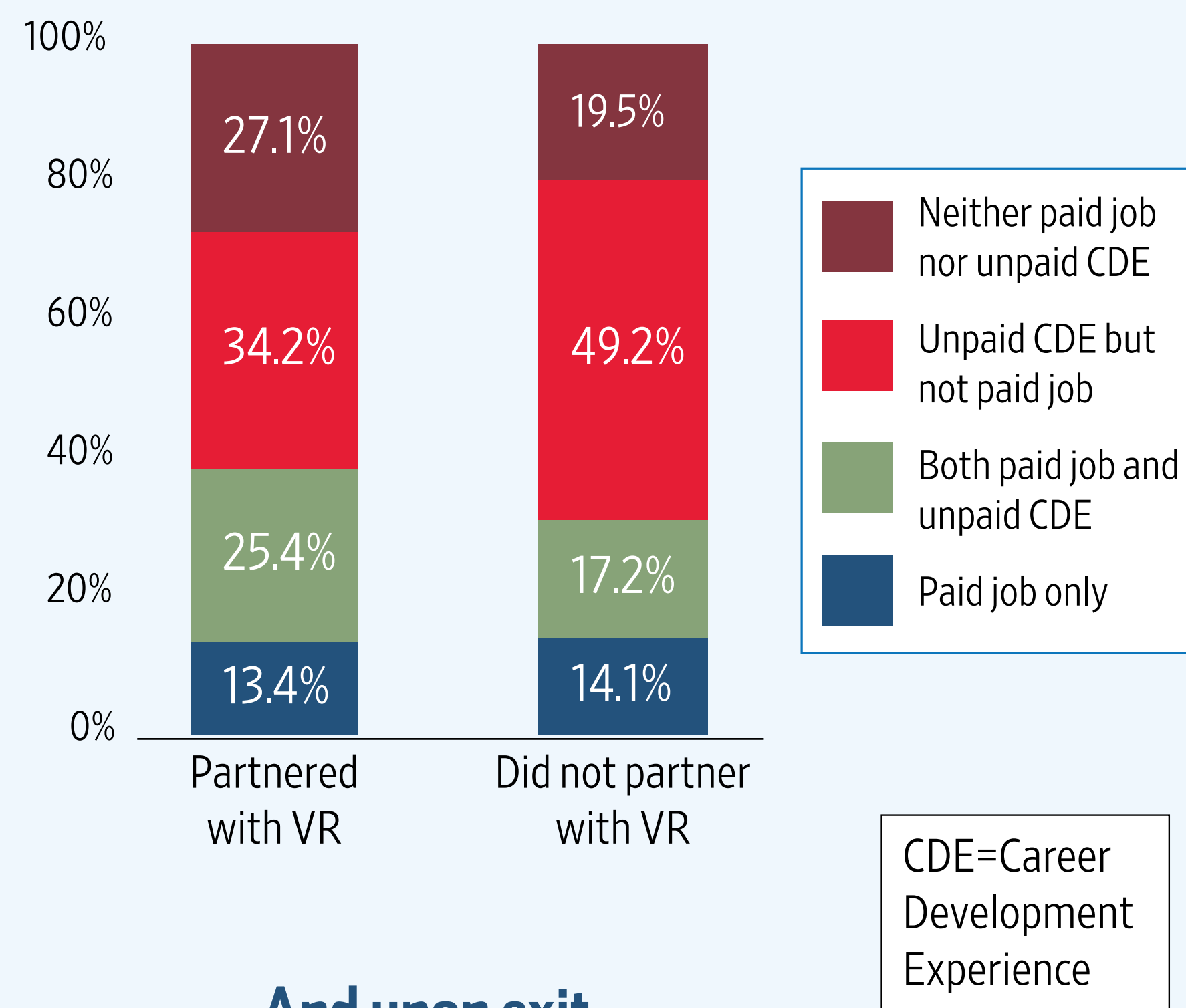
SECONDARY DATA ANALYSIS

Programs partnering with VR have more specialized courses.

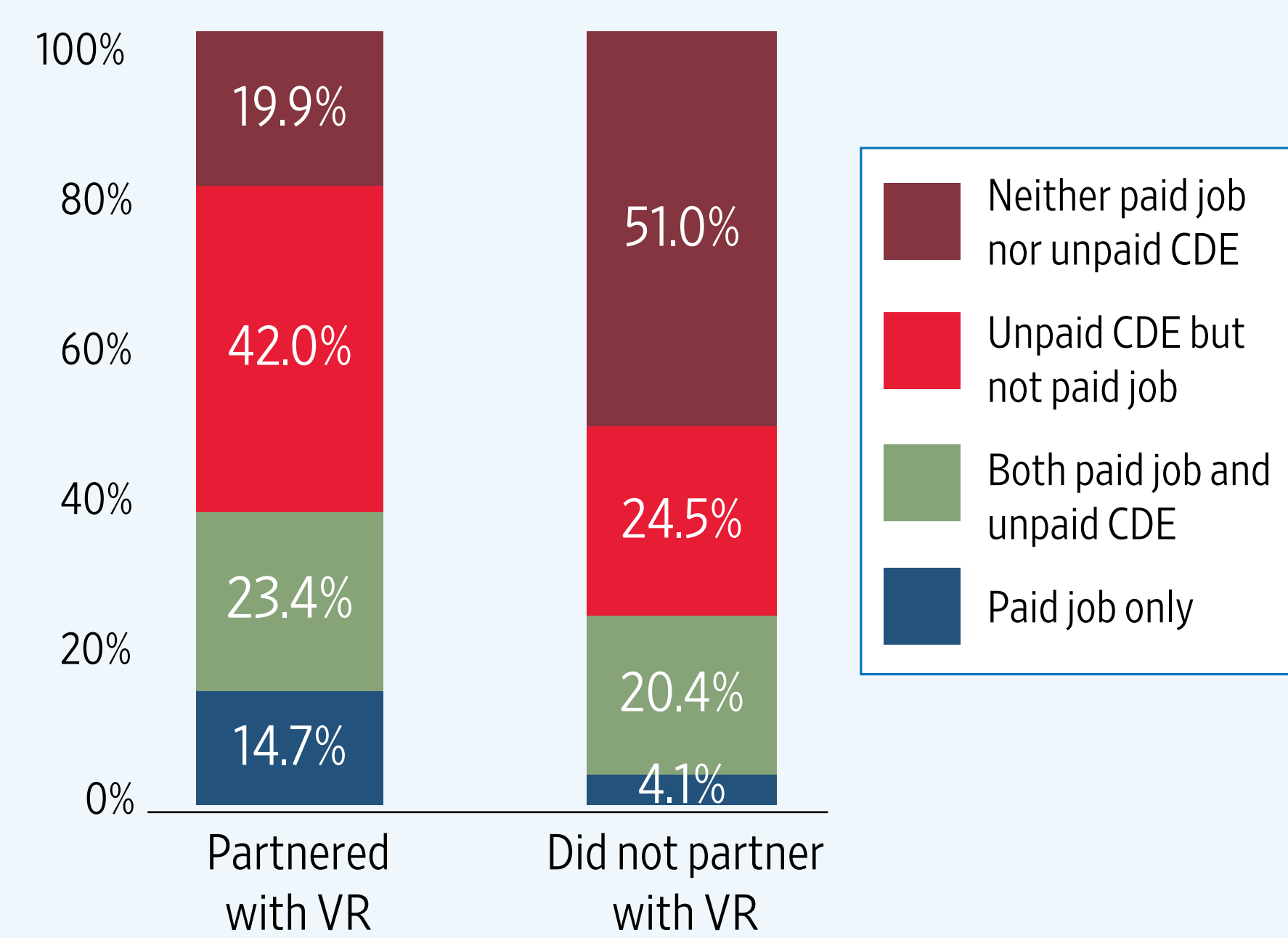
"VR's more interested in paying for specialized courses at this point"
—TPSID program staff



Students in programs with VR partnerships were more likely to have a paid job while in school...



And upon exit



CASE STUDIES

All stakeholders (students, parents, college staff, and VR counselors) believed college presented a tremendous growth opportunity for students, increasing their longer-term potential for independent living and competitive integrated employment. These gains largely involved soft skills and were related to the overall college experience rather than to specific coursework or vocational skills.

"The executive skills that they learn being an equal member on a college campus—you just can't replace that with anything else. And the growth is absolutely amazing; I don't think without that program that most of them would be where they are at."
—VR counselor

VR and IHE partners worked together to support employment outcomes:

- » Each program had a specific expectation and /or timeline around gaining work experience
- » Employment supports to students were provided by IHE staff and supplemented by VR as needed
- » VR and IHE staff, along with students and family members, collaborated around the transition from college to work.

"Generally [students start receiving placement services from VR] in the fall of their last year. [and] that's when we would start that community-based assessment process [and] start interacting with the DVR counselors."

— College employment staff.

ABOUT THE RRTC ON VR AND YOUTH

The Rehabilitation Research and Training Center (RRTC) on Vocational Rehabilitation Practices for Youth and Young Adults addresses the gaps between knowledge and practice to improve VR practices and employment outcomes for youth and young adults with disabilities. Grant Number: 90RT5034-02-01 <http://vrpracticesandyouth.org/>

